



URTICARIAL VASCULITIS

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Urticarial vasculitis is a rare form of vasculitis, an inflammation of the blood vessels, which is characterized by the appearance of urticaria-like skin lesions that typically persist for more than 24 hours and may leave bruising or hyperpigmentation upon resolution. Unlike ordinary **urticaria** (hives), the lesions associated with urticarial vasculitis can be painful or burn rather than just itch.

The exact cause of urticarial vasculitis is often unknown, but it can be associated with various underlying conditions such as infections, drug reactions, systemic lupus erythematosus, and other autoimmune diseases. In some cases, it appears to be idiopathic, meaning no specific cause can be identified. It involves the immune system directly attacking the blood vessels, leading to inflammation and damage.

Symptoms of urticarial vasculitis can vary from person to person but generally include red or skin-colored welts (**wheals**) that can be painful or burn. Additional symptoms may include fever, joint pain, abdominal pain, difficulty breathing, and swollen lymph nodes, depending on the severity and the underlying cause of the vasculitis. The welts associated with urticarial vasculitis differ from ordinary hives in their longer duration and the presence of pain or burning sensations.

Diagnosis of urticarial vasculitis typically involves a thorough medical history, physical examination, and various tests. These tests may include skin **biopsy**, where a small sample of skin is examined under a microscope to look for signs of vasculitis, blood tests to assess inflammation levels and rule out other conditions, and urine tests to check for kidney involvement.

There is no cure for urticarial vasculitis, but treatment focuses on managing symptoms and addressing any underlying conditions. Treatment options may include **antihistamines** to relieve itching, nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs) for pain and inflammation, **corticosteroids** to reduce immune system activity and inflammation, and immunosuppressive drugs for severe cases. Treatment plans can vary widely based on the individual's specific symptoms and the underlying cause of the vasculitis.

Living with urticarial vasculitis can be challenging due to the chronic nature of the disease and the discomfort associated with symptoms. It is important for individuals to work closely with their healthcare providers to manage the condition effectively. Lifestyle adjustments, such as avoiding known triggers and wearing protective clothing, can help reduce the frequency and severity of flare-ups. Support networks and patient advocacy groups can offer resources and support for individuals affected by urticarial vasculitis, helping them to navigate the challenges of living with this rare condition. Early diagnosis and appropriate treatment can significantly improve the quality of life for those with urticarial vasculitis.

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